

amparo. Judicial protection of individual and social rights, however, was hampered throughout the period by declarations of states of emergency, unconstitutional changes in government, growing politicization of the judiciary, and proliferation of special courts outside the jurisdiction and control of the ordinary judiciary.⁷⁹

Despite some improvements in the courts' defense of individual and social rights, the overriding problem with the judiciary remained its failure to defend constitutional democracy. Judicial review to determine the constitutionality of government actions was frequently copied from the United States, but not in all countries and not in full. Even where this judicial practice existed in Latin America, courts used it more narrowly and ineffectually than in the United States. As had been true since independence, it was often unclear who had such authority, how far it went, or how it could be applied or enforced. Many Latin American countries did not really expect courts to uphold constitutional democracy or to resist dictatorship, particularly when the former could suspend the constitution legally to confront emergencies and the latter could drape their usurpation of power in legality. Frequently confronted with arbitrary behavior and *de facto* governments, courts were hard pressed to decide what acts were legal or illegal.

The executive branch viewed these exceptional periods as political questions beyond the jurisdiction of the supreme court. Moreover, the judiciary usually treated the laws promulgated by unconstitutional rulers as legitimate both during the existence of the regime and after its demise, even when a constitutional government followed a dictatorship. The separate sphere of the courts from political issues was reflected in that coup makers more often disbanded the congress than the courts, although they sometimes shuttered both.⁸⁰

In Latin America, the Argentine judiciary probably ranked historically second only to the Chilean as an autonomous, forceful branch of government. Nevertheless, between 1930 and 1970, Argentine governments suspended constitutional guarantees approximately 45 percent of the time, limiting the ability of courts to respond to cases of rights transgressions. The supreme court recognized the *de facto* seizure of power on five separate occasions beginning in 1943. Like those in Brazil, El Salvador, and Peru, it also suffered wholesale purgings, being completely replaced by new regimes six times from 1946 on.⁸¹

During this period, however, judicial capitulation in the face of states of emergency and *de facto* regimes sometimes gave way to judicial resistance, notably in Argentina, where it was least expected. In general, such defiance remained infrequent and ineffective. In any country, confrontation was un-

usual because all Latin American courts generally recognized the legitimacy and legality of extralegal governments. Resistance normally proved futile, due not only to armed intimidation but also to the government's manipulation of law and constitutional provisions as well as judicial careers.⁸²

When Pinochet deposed Allende in 1973, the Chilean supreme court immediately recognized the legality of the dictatorship and its laws. The court ignored the gross violations of human rights. The armed forces quickly boarded up the congress but left the judiciary largely intact. As in some other countries that experienced military rule, the governing junta suspended or amended key parts of the constitution and assumed the legal and legislative authority of the state. This takeover included the expansion of a system of military courts, over which the supreme court surrendered supervisory authority. By the end of the dictatorship, these military courts exercised jurisdiction over more civilians than over armed services personnel.⁸³

From the 1960s to the 1980s, the Latin American courts compiled an abysmal record of protecting constitutions, constitutional democracies, and individual liberties. They offered little legal redress for severe human rights abuses committed under unusually savage military governments. These failings set the stage for a widespread rethinking and revamping of the administration of justice in the following democratic period.⁸⁴

BREAKTHROUGH ELECTIONS

The upsurge of popular democracy permitted and propelled some of the most groundbreaking elections in Latin American history. Voters benefited from expanding access, rights and protections. Nevertheless, they remained hampered by somewhat limited suffrage, a few indirect elections, inefficient and biased electoral systems, corruption and chicanery, manipulation and intimidation by national and local bosses, interventionist militaries, and frail political parties. Although improving, voter effectiveness was also hindered by low levels of education, inadequate information, and glaring socioeconomic disparities.

Some governments still imposed the selection and election of a candidate through multiple shady means. These tactics included controlling registration, juggling nominations, allowing only one candidate, dominating the campaign and media, harassing the opposition, bribing or coercing voters, stuffing the ballot box, and miscounting the results. Although penalties existed for electoral misconduct, fraud and favoritism often besmirched the process, especially in the countryside. Nevertheless, electoral travesties declined thanks to rising urbanization, education, voter participation, and secret ballots.⁸⁵

Amidst widespread democratization of the franchise, some qualifications on voting remained. By 1958, only Paraguay still denied women the national franchise, whereas ten countries had still withheld it by the mid-1940s. Although all countries had scotched property requirements, four (Peru, Ecuador, Chile, and Brazil) still banned illiterates. Peru and some other countries excluded clerics from balloting, while a majority barred the military from the voting booth. While disenfranchising the armed forces, the Ecuadorian constitution of 1946 obliged them to "guarantee the purity of the electoral function." Many countries expected the armed forces to maintain order and propriety during elections.⁸⁶

Electoral reform crowned the trend to amplify and fortify democratic institutions. Many countries expanded suffrage, both by enfranchising new groups such as women, illiterates, and young people and by removing conditions such as income, property, or status. Latin American reformers also cut back qualifications (mainly age) for elected officials. They switched from indirect to direct elections and from majoritarian to proportional representation. In many cases, they made municipal officials elected instead of appointed.

From the perspective of the dictatorial 1970s, these legal advances appeared minor, but from the vantage point of the democratic 1980s, they looked valuable. However, the failure of these significant reforms from the 1930s to the 1960s to generate durable and deep democracies called into question the ability of lesser institutional engineering to achieve that goal from the 1970s to the 2000s. Although institutional changes were important, they could not accomplish all their objectives without fundamental alterations in the underlying structure of power and beliefs. Elites needed to accept the democratic rules of the game.⁸⁷

By the mid-1950s, Latin American constitutions typically bestowed universal suffrage through obligatory and secret voting on all citizens over eighteen years of age, whether male or female, literate or illiterate, property owners or squatters, rich or poor. Equally significant, legal voting rights increasingly coincided with reality. As barriers to the franchise fell, some countries even allowed resident foreigners to vote in municipal elections on the grounds that they were members of the community, a notion of municipality going back to Iberia before the conquest of the New World.

From the 1930s to the 1970s, governments continued lowering the age requirement for suffrage. The Dominican Republic required eighteen years for regular voters but no minimum age for married persons, while Mexico, Honduras, Nicaragua, Costa Rica, and Peru dropped the minimum age to eighteen for married persons, and Nicaragua and Honduras did so for liter-

ates. All of Latin America adopted a lower voting age than the twenty-one years required in the United States.

In this era, the enfranchisement of women caused the most growth in the electorate, expanding the number of voters by 140 percent. Conservatives were as likely as progressives to bring about female suffrage, since they expected to capture most of their votes. Beginning with Ecuador in 1929, three more countries came on board in the 1930s, six in the 1940s, and eight in the 1950s, ending with Paraguay in 1963.

By the mid-1950s, almost all the Latin American countries had removed literacy requirements, while literacy rose in general. For example, in the wake of its 1944 democratic revolution, Guatemala gave the vote to illiterate males, enfranchising all men (thus enrolling many indigenous males) and literate women in the 1945 constitution. But after the upper class, armed forces, and United States extinguished that regime in 1954, Guatemala made voting public and more difficult for illiterates, barred illiterates from offices above the municipality, and still required female voters to be literate.⁸⁸

By the mid-1950s, all the countries required registration to vote. At the same time, most mandated compulsory voting, although they seldom enforced it. Among country variations, Peru's 1933 constitution made voting compulsory up to age sixty. Paraguay assigned to all male citizens of at least eighteen years of age the duty to vote, unless they were criminals or in the military. The constitution of 1940 warned that "persons who preach or proclaim electoral abstention lose their rights as citizens without altering their obligations." The Cuban constitution of 1940 vowed that someone who failed to vote could not hold any public office for two years thereafter. Guatemala's 1945 constitutional enactment of obligatory voting left it optional for illiterates. Ecuador's constitution of 1946 made voting obligatory for men but not for women. Also in 1946, the Brazilian constitution compelled voting by both sexes, but exempted persons under the age of eighteen, illiterates, people not conversant in Portuguese, unemployed women, men over the age of sixty-five, and most enlisted soldiers. Although not prescribed in the constitution, the Argentine electoral system obligated all persons (including women from 1948 on) eighteen years and older to vote, except for criminals, insane people, clergy, members of the armed forces, and deserters from the military.⁸⁹

Some of the highest turnouts in the world transpired in countries with legal penalties for not voting. From the late 1950s to the late 1970s, the participation of eligible voters in elections in ongoing democracies worldwide varied enormously from a low of 59 percent in the United States to a high of 94 percent in Italy. Latin American democracies tended to fall in the

middle range from 70 percent to 80 percent. For example, the average turnout of eligible voters in Chile and Uruguay reached 71 percent, in Costa Rica 73 percent, and in Venezuela 80 percent.⁹⁰

From the 1930s to the 1980s, the percentage of the population participating in Latin American elections skyrocketed. In many cases, it doubled or tripled, after decades of gradual growth. For example, from 1930 to 1940 and 1970 to 1980, voters as a percentage of the population jumped from 20 percent to 61 percent in Uruguay, 12 percent to 52 percent in Argentina, 8 percent to 44 percent in Chile, 15 percent to 33 percent in Costa Rica, 3 percent to 25 percent in Ecuador, and 6 percent to 19 percent in Colombia. In the same period, those figures went from 24 percent to 47 percent in France, from 47 percent to 44 percent in Great Britain, from 40 percent to 43 percent in Canada, from 37 percent to 50 percent in Spain, and from 36 percent to 37 percent in the United States.⁹¹

In contrast with the United States, only Mexico, El Salvador, Nicaragua, Cuba, Venezuela, and Chile (after 1958) used official Australian ballots printed by the government. In the other fourteen countries, parties and candidates prepared the ballots, which made misbehavior easier and ticket splitting nearly impossible. Nearly all the countries formally guaranteed the secrecy of the balloting, but they did not always preserve it in practice.⁹²

Some of the greatest excitement in Latin American elections still occurred after the ballots were cast and even after they were counted. Then intense bargaining often ensued between the winners and losers. The latter frequently threatened to cry foul, dismiss the results as bogus, and even promote destabilization, perhaps resulting in a military takeover. They demanded that the victors—usually the government—make concessions in the final tally, offices, policies, and other spoils. In this tense period, the contenders jockeyed to see who—the opposition, the oligarchy, the Church, the military, the labor unions, the student organizations, the media, or the foreign powers—would recognize the results as valid and at what price.⁹³

To reduce these uncertainties, most Latin American countries devised special agencies to manage elections and deal with results and disputes. For example, the constitutions of Nicaragua in 1939, Cuba in 1940, and Brazil and Ecuador in 1946 created electoral tribunals and judges to oversee the entire electoral process. The Cuban constitution of 1940 instructed this body to be appointed by the courts and to exercise jurisdiction over parties and candidates as well as elections: "From the call for elections until the elected persons take office, the superior electoral tribunal shall have jurisdiction over the armed forces and over the police bodies for the sole purpose of guaranteeing the purity of the electoral function."⁹⁴

In these years, proportional representation (PR) in elections for the legislature spread to a majority of the countries. For example, in congressional and municipal elections, Chile used a version of the D'Hondt system of proportional representation, in which voters chose one of several candidates on a party list. The votes for all candidates on the party list were combined to determine the number of seats won by the party, and those seats went to the candidates of that party with the most votes. As in other parts of Latin America, this meant that candidates ran against members of their own party as well as other parties. However, that feature did not seem to undercut political parties in Chile, as some theories would predict. Although the Socialists split often, other Chilean parties remained quite cohesive. This system favored identification with individual candidates more than in standard PR systems, while also giving parties an important role.⁹⁵

In terms of electoral procedures, Latin America was catching up legally and statistically with the more industrialized democracies. However, the region still suffered by comparison because of the inconsistent rule of law and the virus of corruption. It also lagged behind the United States and Western Europe because of the frequent distortion and interruption of those electoral rights by non-elected powers, principally the dominant social classes and the armed forces, sometimes backed by the United States. Those élites were particularly disposed to shutting down these electoral systems when the winners threatened to use their victories to bring about major social redress, as reformers had done earlier in parts of Western Europe. Consequently, Latin American progressives confronted exceptional challenges in employing democratic politics to achieve significant strides toward social justice.⁹⁶

Among the major countries, elections mattered least in selecting leaders in authoritarian Mexico. The civilian Party of the Institutionalized Revolution (PRI) always won every major election. Presidential and congressional elections occurred regularly on the same day. The official party's massive campaign served several purposes: assuring the expected victory, cowing the opposition, mobilizing voters, sending messages, establishing the personal authority of the incoming president, gathering information from the provinces and municipalities, impressing foreign observers, and generally legitimizing the government. The regime permitted little fair competition in either the conduct of the election or the counting of the ballots, although opposition parties slowly gained ground. From 1910 through 1940, the whopping official margin of victory for the president varied between 99 percent and 94 percent of the votes except for a low of 84 percent in 1924. From 1946 through 1964, those tallies dipped, ranging between 90 percent and 74 percent.⁹⁷

In many other countries, elections took on more crucial importance than ever before, especially for the rise of populists and other reformers. Electoral triumphs for new political forces realigned the balance of power. They opened the way to more vital, popular democracies with increasing mass participation and social reforms.

In this time period, one of the first breakthroughs were the victories of the Colombian Liberals in the presidential elections of 1930 and 1934. Thereafter, they launched the Revolution on the March, a bland version of the general regional trend toward greater state involvement in the economy and society, usually backed by the middle and working classes. In 1958, the other transformative Colombian election brought the National Front to office, a coalition of Liberals and Conservatives dedicated to ending a rare military dictatorship and epidemic violence. Voters cast ballots directly for municipal council, departmental assembly, congress, and president.⁹⁸

During the hemispheric democratic opening around the end of World War II, Guatemala elected a pro-labor, socialistic government headed by Juan José Arévalo in 1944. His elected successor, President Jacobo Arbenz, moved to redistribute land to peasants, including parcels from the United Fruit Company of the United States. Washington used the Central Intelligence Agency to back that government's overthrow in 1954, in one of its first covert anti-democratic interventions of the Cold War. Decades of dictatorship, civil war, and death ensued.⁹⁹

One of the most influential populists in Latin American history, Juan Perón, won election to the presidency in Argentina in 1945, 1951, and later in 1973. Although elected honestly, he governed in an increasingly authoritarian style in the early 1950s, epitomizing delegative popular democracy. Accompanied up to the 1950s by his charismatic wife Evita, Perón instituted far-reaching reforms for nationalistic state protection of the industrializing economy and for rights for workers and women. He commanded a labor-based political party that remained the strongest in his country into the 2000s.

From the 1950s to the 1980s, Perónism and the armed services crossed swords to dominate Argentine politics. After the armed forces abandoned and overthrew Perón in the name of democracy in 1955, the country careened between democratic and authoritarian regimes. Following the military's ouster of Perón's new wife Isabel in 1976, they established an extraordinarily lethal dictatorship that lasted until 1983. According to the best evidence, most Argentines did not favor that authoritarian regime.¹⁰⁰

Brazil also experienced fundamental realigning elections. In 1930, the electoral breakdown of the Old Republic ushered in the authoritarian regime of Vargas until his removal by the military in 1945. Under its fifth

constitution, that of 1946, Brazil embarked on its first modern democratic experiment. The percentage of the total population voting soared from 1 percent at the end of the empire to 6 percent at the end of the Old Republic to 20 percent in 1962.

In 1950, voters returned Vargas to the presidency as the “father of the poor.” He inaugurated a populist system that climaxed with the ascension of his protégé Goulart in 1960. The élites used President Goulart’s rhetorical appeals to the downtrodden to justify the 1964 takeover by the anti-communist military, supported by the United States in the throes of the Cold War. Up to the coup, all polling and electoral data indicated that most Brazilians remained committed to democracy and centrist politics, but those on top had other preferences. The resulting dictatorship became a model for bureaucratic authoritarian regimes in South America until it restored democracy in 1985.¹⁰¹

Like many other countries, Costa Rica underwent democratization in the aftermath of World War II. Following a contested election and brief revolution in 1948, José Figueres convened an elected constituent assembly in 1949 to replace the constitution of 1871. The new charter launched a model democracy and welfare state. Figueres also founded the nation’s most organized, programmatic, and popular political party, the National Liberation Party. The renovated and enduring democracy elected him president in 1953 and 1970.¹⁰²

Another triumph for populism erupted when the Bolivian oligarchy, known as the *Rosa*, tried to steal the election of 1952. Protests by the National Revolutionary Movement (MNR), a populist amalgam of the middle sectors, workers, and peasants, escalated into a pitched battle. It resulted in the party’s takeover and the Bolivian Revolution, which lasted from 1952 through successive elections until the military ejected them in 1964. While in office, the MNR extended the franchise to eighteen-year-olds, women, and illiterates. It promoted economic nationalism, labor rights, and land redistribution. The MNR attempted to replicate the statist economic and social reforms of the Mexican Revolution under one-party rule by the PRI, but this Bolivian variant did not manage to institutionalize itself. Nevertheless, it left a legacy of democracy, mass mobilization, and social justice to be revived in the future.¹⁰³

In 1958, Venezuela, like its neighbor Colombia, terminated a dictatorship and christened a vibrant two-party democracy. Elected president in 1958, Rómulo Betancourt and his populist party of Democratic Action dominated. The government sowed the oil to bring about state intervention in the economy and social welfare.¹⁰⁴

Perhaps the most famous and controversial election in Latin American history occurred in Chile in 1970. The narrow plurality victory of Allende took place in the most staunch and open democracy in the region. It produced the most revolutionary government ever in South America. Going far beyond standard populism, Allende's vow to create socialism through democratic means embodied hope for many leftists at home and abroad. In the cauldron of the Cold War, his redistribution of power and property to workers and peasants aroused equally fervent fears among his opponents in Chile and the United States.

Pinochet's 1973 blitzkrieg smashed democracy and socialism, regardless of the devotion to democracy of a resounding majority of Chileans. The death of Allende and his government, along with many of his supporters, showed that any democracy, however venerable, institutionalized, and deeply supported by its citizens, remained vulnerable to destruction by the military. The coup d'état dealt an enormous setback to Marxism, socialism, revolution and even democratic reform or populism, especially in Latin America and the Third World. The unprecedented ferocity of the coup intimidated progressives throughout the hemisphere and haunted the more timid and moderate democracies that would come later.¹⁰⁵

POPULIST AND LEFTIST POLITICAL PARTIES

In most of Latin America, political parties remained little more than patron-client machines. They suffered from personalistic leadership and divisions, hierarchical organization, cronyism, programmatic vacuity, regional fragmentation, indiscipline and instability, deficient finances, government persecution, and military intervention. Parties usually chose candidates with no direct consultation with the voters, normally at conventions run by bosses, as was largely true in the United States before the expansion of the primary system. In most cases, parties viewed each other as enemy camps engaged in a winner-take-all, zero-sum battle for spoils. They rarely entertained any concept of a loyal opposition.

Nevertheless, political parties made progress and responded more to the unprivileged. In most cases, the sturdiest democracies hosted and benefited from the strongest parties and party systems. The most vibrant party systems rested on stable institutionalized parties that took coherent programmatic positions and incorporated virtually all the key segments of society.¹⁰⁶

As in the United States, almost no national regulation of party organization or behavior existed historically in Latin America. This was true even though many constitutions subjected parties to special laws, which mainly allowed governments to rid themselves of parties they disliked. In these

years, some constitutions increasingly regulated party organizations and behavior, both guaranteeing and limiting their rights. The limitations usually referred to international or ideological orientations, mainly to exclude communists, but the Panamanian constitution also banned parties based on sex, race, or religion.

Ahead of its time, the Cuban constitution of 1940 tried to prevent fly-by-night parties or candidates by requiring all parties to obtain at least 2 percent of the votes in every election and all candidates to run from said parties. That charter also ruled that, "The organization of political parties and associations is free. However, no political groupings of race, sex, or class may be formed."¹⁰⁷

Latin America continued to display a variety of political party systems. At the same time, as in any polity, parties did not offer the only avenues to political influence, often taking a back seat to the military, the Church, business firms, landowners, labor unions, guerrillas, foreigners, and other interest groups. Among one-party dominant systems, some authoritarian governments tolerated only one party (for example in the Dominican Republic and Cuba) and some allowed only one party to win most of the time but permitted other parties to exist (Mexico).

Among competitive party systems, multiparty arrangements remained the most common. The most successful existed in Chile. Two-party systems with both capable of competing for a majority prevailed in Colombia, Venezuela, and Uruguay. Therein, one party normally dominated, most exceptionally the Colorados in Uruguay. The two main parties in all three countries persevered partly because they repeatedly forged power-sharing pacts with each other to avoid political breakdowns and the rise of political rivals. For many decades before Venezuela consolidated its party duopoly, Colombia and Uruguay joined Mexico and Chile in having the most vigorous enduring party systems in Latin America.¹⁰⁸

However, robust political parties provided no guarantee against authoritarianism. Under resilient two-party systems, Colombia became more authoritarian in behavior during the National Front, while Uruguay succumbed in 1973 to a dictatorship that achieved notoriety for torture. In Latin America's hardestiest multiparty system, increasingly ideological parties degenerated into "polarized pluralism," which helped cause the radicalization and breakdown of Chilean politics under President Allende. The disintegration of this system was an exceptional tragedy because "not only did Chile have the best record of constitutional government and free elections of any major Latin American country, but it also displayed the most highly structured party system of the continent."¹⁰⁹

From the 1930s to the 1970s, new parties added to the traditional lineup of Conservatives, Liberals, secular centrist groups like the Radicals in Chile and Argentina, Socialists, Communists, and regional or personalistic vehicles. Within party spectrums, class and ideological cleavages became important alongside older religious or regional divisions. A few small fascist parties sprouted briefly in the 1930s. Much more importantly, new centrist reform parties dubbed Christian Democrats arose in several countries. They enjoyed the greatest success in Chile, Venezuela, El Salvador, and Peru.

Populist parties provided the most significant newcomers. They reflected the upsurge of the lower classes, especially organized labor. Usually dominated by personalistic electoral caudillos, these heterogeneous parties included the APRA in Peru, the Socialists in Chile from the 1930s to the 1950s, Democratic Action in Venezuela, the Perónists in Argentina, the MNR in Bolivia, the Brazilian Labor Party, and numerous smaller examples. In many cases, these populist parties generated not only expanded social participation and reform but also implacable resistance from élites, leading to polarization, stalemate, and breakdown.¹¹⁰

In the twentieth century, revolutionary parties also strode forth. Although powerful intermediaries between the state and society, they subordinated themselves to the government of the revolutionary élites. The heirs of the revolution commanded these parties in an authoritarian, vertical manner, mobilizing mainly workers and peasants. They claimed to be more than just another party, because they represented the revolution and the nation against excluded oligarchic enemies. They aspired to create hegemonic one-party systems, usually wiping out previous, historically fragile contenders. The revolutionary parties in Mexico and Cuba established their monopoly for a long period, but those in Bolivia and Nicaragua failed to maintain their grip on power.

Conclusion

From the 1930s to the 1970s, protected democracy temporarily ceded space to popular democracy, often captained by populists. Without discarding many of their traditional features, both political ideas and institutions reflected the demand for democracy to embrace social justice. The historically most democratic countries still led the way. Overall, however, no clear regime tendency took hold, as democracies alternated with dictators, either of which could be inclusionary or exclusionary. Both anarchy and especially tyranny continued to tear asunder democracies.

Among political institutions, constitutions multiplied and added social and economic guarantees to incorporate the unprivileged and national development. To serve these same purposes, central governments and presidencies expanded their size and power. Some chief executives increasingly respected civil liberties. Although gaining a little leverage, legislatures remained weak. Nevertheless, confrontations between conservative congresses and populist presidents frequently triggered military coups. Reformers made a few judiciaries more independent. But the courts revealed their lack of accessibility and their inability or unwillingness to defend human rights and constitutional democracy under dictatorships. In most cases, the strongest political parties and party systems sustained the hardest democracies. While populist and leftist parties rose at the polls, they encountered defeat at the barracks.

Popular democracy achieved the greatest victories through elections. Reformers amplified the suffrage, enrolling vast numbers of women, illiterates, and young people, while deleting economic restrictions. Many countries installed direct elections, municipal elections, and proportional representation. The proliferation of voters, secret ballots, and electoral tribunals diminished fraud. These institutional advances facilitated breakthrough elections for the disadvantaged majority, which frightened the upper classes into abandoning democratic institutions.

In the context of the escalating Cold War of the 1960s and 1970s, both the left and the right increasingly turned against electoral democracy in Latin America. Inspired by Castro, many on the left argued that only undemocratic revolutionary means could bring about national development and social justice. Backed by the United States, many on the right feared that democracy was the antechamber rather than the antidote to revolution and so supported reactionary dictators.¹¹¹

The military takeovers in Uruguay and Chile in 1973 produced the two most shocking losses for democracy. Most polling and electoral data indicated that the overwhelming majority of Uruguayans continued to favor democracy and moderate political positions up to the end, including 79 percent in late 1972. Surveys on the eve of the coup in Chile still showed that over two-thirds of the citizens opposed military intervention and rule. In both countries, the élites, not the masses, turned against these long-standing democratic regimes.¹¹²

After the dramatic democratic gains from the 1930s to the 1970s, the onslaught of a new dictatorial era in the 1960s and 1970s proved especially disappointing and sobering to democrats. The rightwing authoritarian

forces mainly stamped out popular, populist, and leftist threats. In the most developed countries of the Southern Cone, events took a particularly grim turn as a new style of tyranny appeared. These bureaucratic authoritarian regimes became much more ruthless and long-lasting than previous autocratic governments. It looked to some scholars as though modernization was leading to even worse despotisms, not democracies. It seemed to others that a deep-seated cultural propensity toward authoritarianism was reasserting itself.

Although structural or cultural arguments were hard to prove, one pattern remained indelibly clear. Once again, Latin America's conservative military and civilian élites had dispensed with democracy. The armed forces were key actors, but they did not act alone. In most of these latest cases, they did so with the backing of the hegemonic United States. They defeated democracy, but not for long. After the authoritarians delivered the harshest blows to popular democracy, a more cautious variety of protected democracy soon returned.¹¹³

Chapter 7

The Tsunami of Neoliberal Democracies, 1970s–2000s

Previous waves of democracy had rolled over Latin America, but never before had a tsunami flooded the entire region. From the late 1970s to the 2000s, Latin America became more democratic than ever before, but not because of any massive institutional engineering. The basic formal political rules and organizations for these democracies did not change much, but behavior did. Why did these enormous democratic regime transformations occur and endure?

Although the Latin Americans revised some constitutions and adopted several new ones, they maintained most of the key features from the past, along with an amplified emphasis on social rights. A majority of the political systems remained centralist rather than federalist. However, more decentralization than ever before, mainly to municipalities rather than provinces, became the biggest institutional innovation in the era.

Many political scientists advocated converting to parliamentary systems, but no country followed that advice. Presidents became even more powerful, despite the long-recommended fortification of not only sub-national governments but also legislatures and judiciaries. A few of the chief executives acquired the right to be reelected immediately. They exerted more control over the armed forces and almost never succumbed to military ouster. The new democracies restored civil liberties and human rights but continued to abuse them.